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RMIT University Vietnam, Saigon South Campus



Topic 5: Practise Performance Conversation with AMO Framework

Assoc. Professor Yin Teng (Elaine) Chew

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About Elaine Chew



Qualifications

- **Ph.D.** in International Development (Nagoya University, Japan); scholarship.
- **Master's degree** in Commerce (Otaru Shoodai, Japan); scholarship.
- **Bachelor of Business** (Management) (Monash University, Australia)
- Golden Key award recipient.
- HRM Scholar Award.

Current portfolio at RMIT Vietnam

- **Interim Head** of Department of Management
- Management, Tourism, Organizational Change **research cluster leader**
- Teaches MBA & undergraduate

Skills & competencies

- Publications in the field of HRM, organizational psychology, business strategy,
- **Certified LSP facilitator**.
- Trained in **lean production system**.
- 13 PhD supervision completions.
- Won 5 Teaching Excellence awards at Monash Malaysia.
- Won 2 Research Excellence awards at Monash Malaysia.

Work experience

- 16 years Associate Professor at **Monash University (Ranked 37th), Malaysia.**
- 4 years in other universities in Malaysia.
- 1 year in **an Australian marketing research consulting firm**.
- Designed & launched mystery shopping program for customer service assurance for a bank.
- Developed a **consultancy report for SMECorp**, Malaysia for G-to-G lean production skill transfer in the automotive industry (2010).
- Developed **a consultancy report for JETRO,** Japan for semiconductor sector in Malaysia for bilateral FDI with Japan (2022).
- Co-developed **a consultancy report for KPMG Hong Kong & PBEC** on global sourcing, movement and challenges (2023).

Session outline

1. Explain the principles of sustainable performance management and the role of continuous performance conversations.
2. Conduct performance conversations – clarify expectations, strengthen accountability & support staff development.
3. Apply coaching and feedback techniques to address performance challenges and promote individual growth.
4. Reframe Performance Discussions from Operational Problems to Strategic Decisions

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Sustainable performance management & role of performance conversation

Image by Freepik on Magnific



1. Traditional performance management



Image by Upklyak on Magnific

- Often focuses on evaluating past performance:
  - Did targets get achieved?
  - Was the project delivered?
  - Did the employee meet expectations?
  - What rating should be assigned?
- Important questions but they are *insufficient* in today's technology environment.
- High performance is not simply about achieving *short-term results*.
- Sustainable performance management focuses on ensuring employees can continue performing effectively over time without burnout, disengagement, capability gaps, or organisational barriers

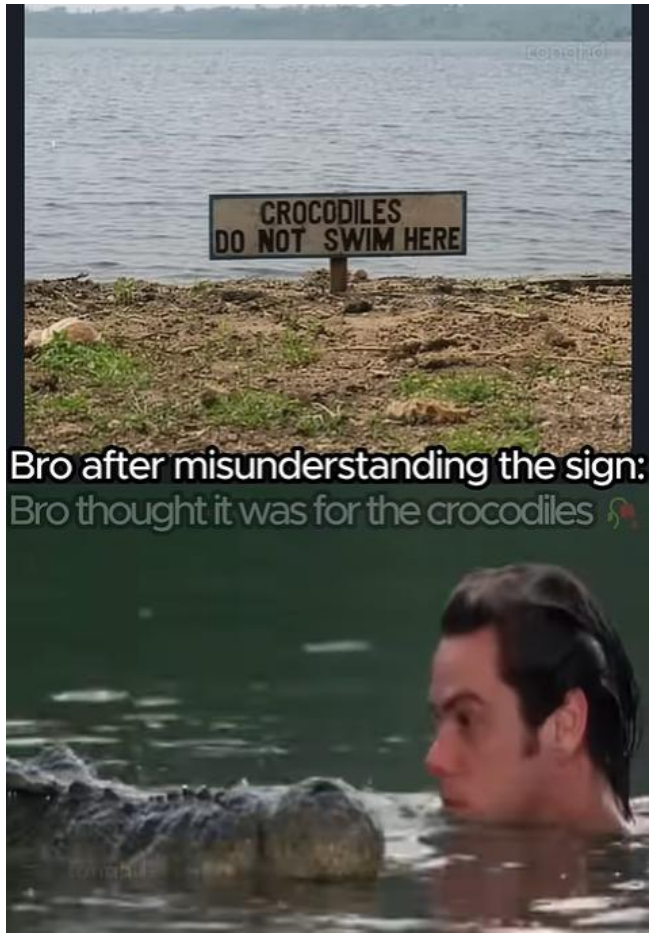
2. Sustainable performance conversations

- Sustainable performance conversations *are not mainly about giving feedback*.
- They are about helping managers *think like executives*.
- *Rushing to the causes* → *bias in* judging performance too quickly.



Communication....

Text



https://youtube.com/shorts/Tonq7qO_4xw?si=DiFAwc-pDsdkucgD

Non Face-to-Face conversation



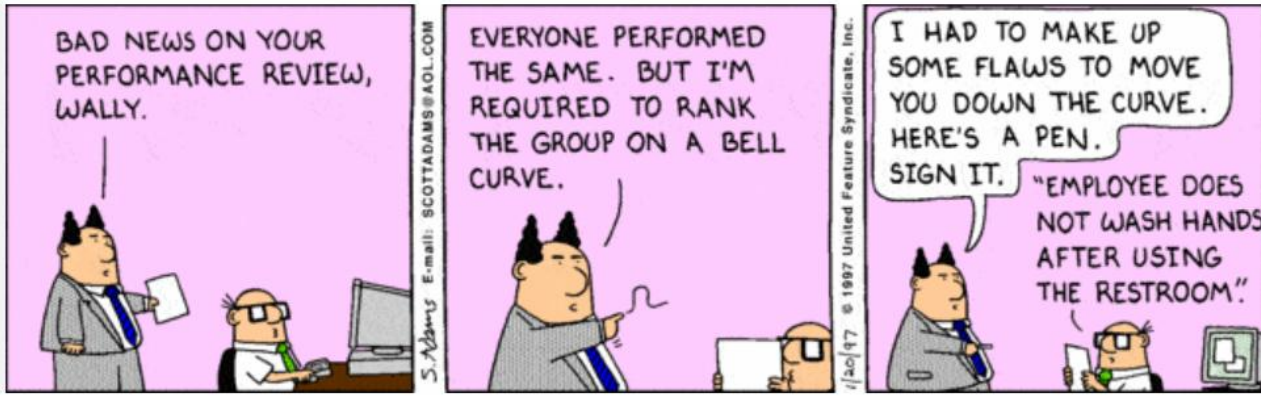
https://youtube.com/shorts/hYlb_uex0U4?si=P5VScCH7Y2A676fd

Do you want such a manager for performance management?

GOALS: SURPRISE!!



REVIEW RATINGS: MEANINGLESS



REWARDS → COST-SAVING



'FEEDBACK' & 'MOTIVATION'



Why is this performance review not a good part of performance conversation?



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hI1Xejz5YnU

2. Sustainable performance conversations

- *Leaders resist* the temptation to judge performance too quickly → audited mindset to reduce bias.
- *They diagnose* whether the underlying issue is 🧩 **Ability,** 🔥 **Motivation,** 🔑 **Opportunity**, or a combination of all three.
- ***Ongoing conversation***: Not until performance review



Image by pressfoto on Magnific



2. Sustainable performance conversations

- Sustainable performance management recognises that performance emerges from the interaction of:



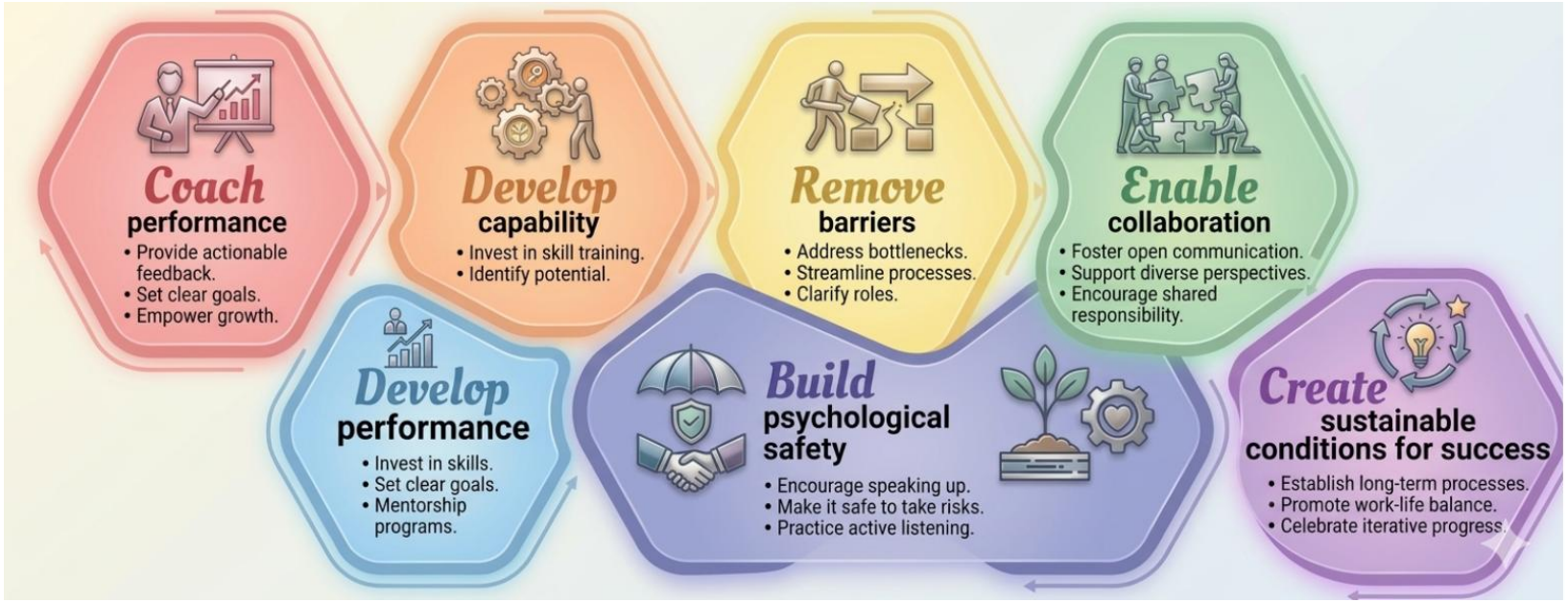
2. Sustainable performance conversations

- Often, organizational problems are often disguised as employee problems
- Examples: Poor processes, resource constraints, unclear priorities, excessive workload
- As a result, managers must look beyond measuring performance outcomes and seek to understand the conditions/context that enable or constrain performance.



2. The changing role of managers

- Today, managers are increasingly expected to:



- This requires **a shift in mindset**.
- Instead of asking: "How do I improve this employee's performance?“
- Managers should ask: "What is helping or preventing this employee from performing at their best?"

2. The role of performance conversations

They help managers:

- **Understand Performance Drivers**
  - What is working? What is not working?
  - What barriers exist?
  - What support is needed?
- **Diagnose Root Causes (AMO diagnostic lens)**
  - Is this an 🧩 **Ability** issue? Knowledge, skill, experience, training
  - Is this a 🔥 **Motivation** issue? Engaged with responsibilities, energising
  - Is this an 🔑 **Opportunity** issue? Resource, barriers (structure, process)
- **Build Employee Capability**
  - Develop skills, strengthen judgement
  - Increase self-awareness
  - Support career growth
- **Improve Organisational Performance**



Image by macrovector on Magnific



2.3 Not all performance conversations are the same

No. 1,2,3,4	Performance level	Conversation focus	Manager's role
1	**Exceeding expectations**	Growth & stretch opportunities	Coach
2	Meeting expectations ★★☆ 3/5	Development & continuous improvement	Facilitator
3	Below expectations	Performance improvement & support	Diagnostician & coach
4	Persistent Underperformance	Performance recovery & accountability	Coach

- **Move away from "Performance = Results" Mindset**
  - Performance conversation is NOT to judge performance but to improve it.

Communication.... Listening skills



https://youtube.com/shorts/SP6RuDD-2WQ?si=bomH85vUXYZlfAIC



https://youtube.com/shorts/WGxUAedAfvg?si=bd3THXK8y2WHm_N2

3. Performance conversations

- **Move away from "Performance = Results" Mindset**
  - How many of you have employees who consistently hit targets but there are other employees that you worry about?
  - Why? Are the reasons related to performance?
- **Investigate AMO 🧩 🔥 🔑 when employee performance declines:**

🧩 Ability

- Does the employee know what good performance looks like?
- Do they have the required skills?
- Have expectations been clearly communicated?
- Have they received adequate training?

🔥 Motivation

- Does the employee want to perform?
- Are they engaged?
- Do they see value in the work?
- Are there morale or wellbeing concerns?

🔑 Opportunities

- Does the employee have the resources needed?
- Are processes helping or hindering?
- Are priorities conflicting?
- Is workload realistic?

3.1 Performance conversations

- **Move away from "Performance = Results" Mindset**
  - How many of you have employees who consistently hit targets but there are other employees that you worry about?
  - Why?
  - Are the reasons related to performance?
- **Investigate 🧩 🔥 🔑 AMO when employee performance declines:**
  - We should not immediately blame attitude.
  - Example 1: An AI engineer suddenly *misses milestones*: Manager thinks performance slipped.
    - ***Reality:*** A new Generative AI framework was introduced. The employee has not yet mastered it.
    - ***Diagnosis:*** _____ Issue
    - ***Conversation:***_____
      _____
      _____?

3.2 Performance conversations

- **Investigate 🧩 🔥 🔑 AMO when employee performance declines:**
  - We should not immediately blame attitude.
  - Example 2: A Product Owner fails to deliver roadmap objectives: Manager thinks performance slipped.
    - ***Reality:***
      - Engineering priorities changed three times.
      - Business stakeholders added new requirements weekly.
    - ***Diagnosis:*** _____ Issue
      - This is not an employee performance problem.
      - It is a work system problem.
    - ***Conversation:***_____
      _____
      _____?

What is commonly important/valuable to people may not be true



https://youtube.com/shorts/E5885eYb41c?si=mDrNuuZ7bVEqqvP-



https://youtube.com/shorts/94M7wLbVYps?si=G9ewG2xSl0I2YMO6

3.3 Performance conversations

- **Investigate 🧩 🔥 🔑 AMO when employee performance declines:**
  - Example 3: A Data Scientist's results remain acceptable.: Manager thinks performance is a no-surprise but could do better.
    - ***Reality:***
      - Participation is minimal. Team engagement is declining.
      - Innovation suggestions have disappeared.
    - ***Diagnosis:*** _____ Issue
      - The manager must explore:
        - Career _____
        - Recog_____
        - Work _____
    - ***Conversation:***_____
      _____
      _____?



Image by Lifestylememory

4. Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

SAIL

- 🎯 ***S = State the gap***
- 👥 ***A = Ask and understand***
- 🔍 ***I = Identify root causes (AMO*** 🧩 🔥 🔑 ***)***
- 🚀 ***L = Launch improvement actions***

2. The role of performance conversations

They help managers:

- **Understand Performance Drivers**
  - What is working? What is not working?
  - What barriers exist?
  - What support is needed?
- **Diagnose Root Causes (AMO diagnostic lens)**
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- **Build Employee Capability**
  - Develop skills, strengthen judgement
  - Increase self-awareness
  - Support career growth
- **Improve Organisational Performance**



Image by macrovector on Magnific



Evidence is a must for performance management



https://youtube.com/shorts/vEXKEKaWxfk?si=V9exal2ypvhs1wQo

What evidence is important for the wife?

4.1 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL (1)

- 🎯 ***S = State the gap***
  - Use objective facts;
    - KPI reports
    - Customer feedback
    - Error rates
    - Project delivery data
    - Stakeholder feedback
  - Examples:
    - "Over the last three months, the target was 95% service accuracy. The average achieved was 77%. This gap requires improvement."
    - "I want to discuss your recent performance results because they are currently below the expected standard for the role"
    - "I noticed recent project milestones have been difficult to achieve."



Image by Freepik on Magnific

4.1 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL (2)

- 🎯 ***S = State the gap***
  - Example: “Over the last three months, the target was 95% service accuracy. The average achieved was 77%.”
    - *Avoid:*
      - “Your performance has been poor. Go and fix it”
      - “Why are you underperforming?”
      - “Your performance is unacceptable. You need to improve”
      - “You need to improve your attitude.”
    - ***Try using these:***
      - “Let's explore what is making it difficult to achieve the expected results.” (remove barriers)
      - “What specific actions can help close the performance gap?”
      - “Let's discuss what success would look like & how we can get there.”
      - “I'd like to better understand your experience and explore what support may help.”

State the gap: Being fair and honest in courting



https://youtube.com/shorts/PKpff2iTQDY?si=iHlnpAKSl7UwlcHr

Here is a couple.

Is the man attractive?

Is the lady attractive?

4.2 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 👥 ***A = Ask and understand***
  - Use diagnostic questioning →What conditions are ***enabling*** or ***constraining*** sustainable performance?
    - **What challenges** are affecting your performance?
      - “What percentage of critical work depends solely on you?”
    - **What obstacles** are you encountering?
      - “Which activities should you stop doing?”
    - **What support** would be helpful?
      - “Which responsibilities could be transferred?”
      - “Where are you experiencing overload?”

4.3 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🔍 ***I = Identify root causes***
  - Map responses against AMO 🧩 🔥 🔑
    - *Discuss:*
      - “From what you've shared, it seems *workload and competing priorities* may be major contributors.” (Opportunity)
      - “From our conversation, it seems that the *work has become mundane and less meaningful* to motivate you.” (Motivation)
      - “From what you've shared, it seems the AI direction we are moving towards is *too demanding for your current skills*.” (Ability)

4.4 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🚀 ***L = Launch improvement actions***
  - Discuss and agree on:
    - **Step 1: Expectations**
    - **Step 2: Support required**
    - **Step 3: Timeline**
    - **Step 4: Follow-up checkpoints**
  - Performance recovery agreement



Image by rawpixel.com on Magnific

4.4 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🚀 ***L = Launch improvement actions***
  - **Step 1: Agree on performance expectations**
    - ***Discussion Question*:**
      - What *performance standard* needs to be achieved?
      - What *evidence* will demonstrate improvement?
      - What *behaviours* are expected?
    - ***Purpose:*** Clarify exactly what successful performance looks like
      - Specific performance outcomes
      - Behavioural expectations
      - Quality standards
      - Productivity targets
    - *Current → Required performance → Evidence*

4.4 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🚀 *L = Launch improvement actions*
  - **Step 2: Agree on support mechanism**
    - 🧩 **Ability-based support**
      - Skill training
      - Refresher program
      - Mentoring
      - Shadowing high performers
      - Job aids and guides

4.4 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🚀 *L = Launch improvement actions*
  - **Step 2: Agree on support mechanism**
    - 🧩 **Ability-based support**
      - Skill training, Mentoring, Job aids and guides
    - **Agreement example:**
      - **Step 2:** Employee → Attend advanced R programming skills
      - **Step 2:** Manager/team leader → Provide weekly coaching for 30 minutes
        - What progress have you made?
        - What challenges remain?
        - What support is needed?
      - **Step 3:** Duration → 4 weeks
      - **Step 4:** Progress noting → Upskilling for each of the 4 weeks

4.4 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🚀 ***L = Launch improvement actions***
  - **Step 2: Agree on support mechanism**
    - 🔥 **Motivation-based support**
      - Career development discussion, More meaningful work assignments, Recognition for improvement
    - **Agreement example:**
      - **Step 2:** Employee →Complete weekly reflection on career development related new projects/responsibilities/tasks
      - **Step 2:** Manager/team leader → Provide fortnightly career coaching discussion;
        - What progress have you made?
        - What challenges remain?
        - What support is needed?
      - **Step 3:** Duration → 12 weeks
      - **Step 4:** Progress noting → Learning reflection

4.4 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🚀 *L = Launch improvement actions*
  - **Step 2: Agree on support mechanism**
    - 🔥 **Motivation-based support**
      - Clarification of role importance
      - Wellbeing support
    - **Agreement example:**
      - **Step 2:** Employee → Complete weekly reflection on progress
      - **Step 2:** Manager/team leader → Provide fortnightly role clarification discussion
      - **Step 3:** Duration → 4 weeks
      - **Step 4:** Progress noting → Learning reflection

4.4 Conversation approach for underperformance: SAIL

- 🚀 *L = Launch improvement actions*
  - **Step 2: Agree on support mechanism**
    - 🔑 **Opportunity-based support**
      - Workload reallocation
      - Process simplification
      - Resource provision
      - Clarification of priorities
      - Removal of barriers
  - **Agreement example:**
    - **Step 2:** Employee → Focus on Project A & B only (need similar skills)
    - **Step 2:** Manager/team leader → Transfer Project C responsibilities to another team member
    - **Step 3 & 4:** Timeline & progress → depend on operational needs



Image by Lifestylememory

Unleashing Potentials through Playful Learning via the Lego Serious Play® Methodology



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PRME 2026 GLOBAL FORUM

PRME Week 28 June - 1 July

Honorable Mention Recognition for Education Excellence



Elaine YinTeng Chew
Interim Head of Department, Managemen, TBSt (Certified LSP Facilitator)



Professor Robert McClelland
Dean of The Business School, RMIT University, Vietnam



Dr. Trang Le
Lecturer
(Certified LSP Facilitator)



Dr. Thao Luong
Senior Program Manager
(Certified LSP Facilitator)



Dr. Jessica Helmi
Senior Lecturer
(Certified LSP Facilitator)



Dr. Chuyen Nguyen
Lecturer

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Dr. Trang Le
Lecturer

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Mr. Vincent Ha Quach
Associate Lecturer

(Certified LSP Facilitator)

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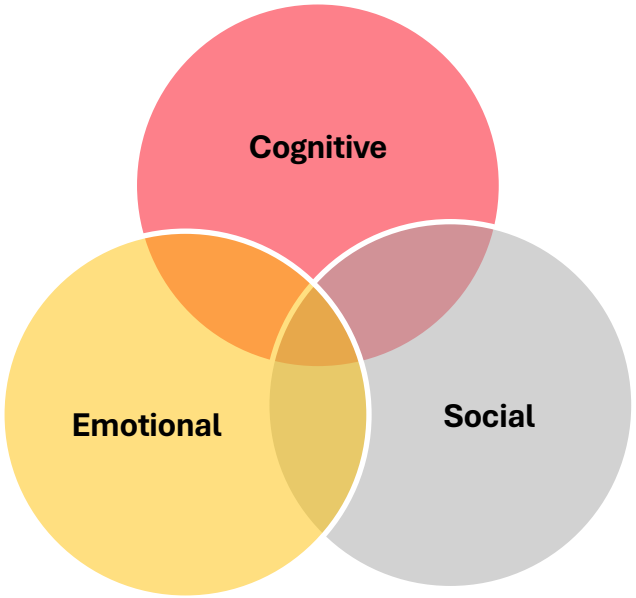
Why learning through playing (LSP pedagogy)?



FUN LEARNING



COMMUNICATION





PARTICIPATIVE
→ SOLUTION



TEAMWORK &
BRAINSTORMING





LSP in the classroom & corporate training

Entrepreneurship & MBA courses (Design thinking, HRM)
(Problem-solving (Kyons); Team building; Problem identification)

Negotiation and conflict management course:
(Negotiation skills; Effective roleplay; Engagement and feedback)

Cross-cultural communication course:
(Identification of challenges & solution development)

LSP® to unpack the Singapore Red Cross Business Challenge
(SIM Integrate Business Perspective for revenue generation)

Corporate training: Leadership skill development
(Executive Presence, Communication etc)



Let’s (Seriously) play!



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Your play time!!!

- Question for ideas: Considering Zalo's company culture and what you learnt today, how could Zalo improve performance conversation?
- In 3 minutes, based on your ideas, build a LEGO model that shows your ideas for Zalo's performance management/conversation.



Your LEGO model photo time!!!

- Take a photo. Upload your LEGO model photo onto Padlet with
  - (I) the title of your model
  - (II) a description of your model (less than 10 words in English or no limit for Vietnamese language).





Your group model photo time!!!

- Take a photo. Upload your LEGO model photo onto Padlet with
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Thank you!

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